

State of the Data

Since its inception in early 2020, the Data Analytics Strategy Management (DASM) division has been gradually laying a foundation for modernizing data management within the Fairfax County Fire & Rescue Department (FRD). Our focus has been to deliver value quickly and continuously by creating insights from data, supporting continuity of operations, eliminating and automating manual processes, and replacing paper processes with smarter, mobile-friendly applications. We have received incredible feedback from all levels of the organization and are humbled by everyone's attitude and support in our mission. However, our progress toward fostering a healthy data culture has not been without its challenges. It has become evident that the greatest challenges transcend our ability to solve alone.

Our data culture is defined by our collective attitude, discipline, and curiosity toward data. As such, data stewardship is not limited to a small number of data experts. Anyone who conceives, designs, creates, explores, trusts, shares, or destroys data is an active participant in our data culture. In our view, our only path toward a healthy and resilient data culture is to embrace transparency and inclusivity, where open dialogue amongst cross-domain experts is vital for achieving our goals. This realization led us to ask the question: who is qualified to facilitate such a discussion? DASM proposes this charter to establish a Data Governance Committee (DGC) who will champion data stewardship from every corner of the organization and facilitate discussions around FRD's data culture.

Why a Data Governance Committee?

One of the most common reasons data governance programs fail is by using a top-down or "waterfall" approach. This method assumes that a small group of capable individuals fully understand all relevant business domains to make informed decisions on how best to manage data across an entire organization. Over the past decade, entire industries and large government agencies have proven a better approach by opening restrictive governance to a broader audience. This allows anyone in the organization to contribute wisdom granted by their expertise, including the nuances between respective knowledge domains. In this way, all participants in the organization can ask questions, provide insights, and offer unique perspectives that would otherwise never be heard.

General Roles and Responsibilities

Through executive sponsorship, a DGC would serve as FRD's recognized authority of data stewardship and has the following responsibilities:

- (1) define principles that identify what is most important to FRD's data culture,
- (2) inform the creation of data management standards, policies, and procedures,
- (3) take the pulse of FRD's data culture to ensure it upholds to established principles,
- (4) facilitate discussions of data issues reported by FRD personnel,
- (5) curate a centralized repository of trusted and reliable data sources for FRD consumption, and
- (6) engaging with FRD's peers and external partners on topics of data governance,
- (7) prepare and deliver periodic "State of the Data" reports to FRD and executive leadership.

Core Principles

Good data governance is underpinned by core principles to which most everyone would agree. They are a starting point for every discussion. A reminder of what is most important to the Fairfax County Fire & Rescue Department as it navigates through future problems and challenges related to data.

Once created, the committee's first task is to produce a list of core principles that should be evident in every DGC discussion, decision, and outcome. This ensures that DGC topics and recommendations do not stray far from what has already been established as "most important" to the organization. These principles are not meant to be monolithic but are expected to evolve with the needs and views of FRD personnel, leadership, and stakeholders.

Committee Voting

The DGC does not create policy, nor does it vote on any determinations or outcomes from its discussions. Rather, it serves as a facilitator and mentor to guide decisions and create awareness of what considerations should be taken along the way. Over time, this knowledge and understanding will cascade into the creation of data-specific standards, policies, and procedures. However, any committee member who has concerns about DGC discussions, decisions, or guidance can document a dissenting opinion that will be distributed to all committee members and executive sponsorship. While dissenting opinions may not necessarily change the outcome of the DGC's consensus views, it establishes a record of unaddressed concerns, enabling the voice of FRD's data culture to always be heard.

Measuring Progress

Progress must be measured, and our data culture is no exception. The DGC will periodically release a survey to all FRD personnel to gather data on the health of FRD's data culture. Specific metrics will be defined and evaluated over time to determine trends and inform future DGC strategies.

Committee Meetings

The DGC would meet periodically to discuss issues brought to its attention, identify root problems, and determine what actions (if any) are necessary for resolution. Over time its discussions and decisions will provide a clear and practical framework for defining many department standards, policies, and procedures for how data should be designed, collected, developed, stored, utilized, and destroyed.

In accordance with its goals to remain transparent and inclusive, all DGC are advertised and accessible to all FRD personnel.

Centralized Data Dictionary (Metadata Repository)

Accurate knowledge of what data exists, where it is stored, and how it is currently managed is essential to the DGC's success. Therefore, the DGC is responsible for creating and maintaining a comprehensive data inventory or metadata repository. This repository captures the department's best understanding of what data exists, where it is stored, its authoritative source, and whatever nuanced caveats and limitations are relevant for its consumption. This allows the DGC to identify and establish what data should be considered "trusted and reliable" for decision makers across the organization. It also enables proper collaboration by clearly identifying isolated data sources (silos) that are either duplicative or

redundant. Finally, it also enables responsible records management by identifying legacy data that can be scheduled for archival (cold storage) or deletion.

Committee Membership

Diversified membership is critical to ensure all relevant perspectives are present in DGC discussions and decisions. Therefore, the committee comprises cross-domain membership to include a wide range of relevant expertise, including operations, department administration, executive leadership, information technology, data analytics, geographic information systems (GIS), communications, and more. Although every knowledge domain may not be relevant to every discussion, diverse membership ensures the DGC can offer accurate, impactful guidance through its discussions and decisions. Some committee members will inherit membership by virtue of their position, others can be appointed as needed.

Committee Members

Seat	Person
OPS BUREAU	BC Christopher Blair
ADMIN BUREAU	BC Matt Cox
OFFICE OF FIRE CHIEF	BC Kristopher Johnson
HIPAA OFFICER / RMS	Captain Steve Hartman
COMMUNICATIONS/CAD	Captain Tim Adkins
FOIA OFFICE	Sandra Rodriguez
DATA MANAGER	John Morrison
DATA SECTION LEAD	Jessica LeBlanc
GIS SECTION LEAD	Charles Galloway
DATABASE ADMINISTRATOR	John Hanke
INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY MANAGER	Steve Dennis
FIRE MARSHALS OFFICE	TBD
HUMAN RESOURCES	TBD
OTHERS	

Expected Outcomes

If the DGC is successful in its mission to foster a healthy data culture, we would expect to benefit from the following outcomes:

- Improved understanding of where to access data.
- Improved understanding of what trusted data can be used to inform a decision.
- FRD's data management practices align with other mature organizations.
- Prevent creation of new data "silos" that prevent accurate and reliable reporting.
- Prevent permanent loss or control of FRD data.
- Prevent improper disclosure of protected information, including PHI.
- Prevent unintended disclosure or control of protected information.
- Remain compliant with all FOIA obligations.
- Remain compliant with all HIPAA regulations.
- Remain compliant with Fairfax County policies and procedures.

- Ensure FRD data governance persists beyond the tenure of its original creators, sponsors, and beneficiaries.